

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **Sony Pictures' "Spider-Man: Brand New Day"** opened to an estimated \$927 million in global box-office sales, making it the second-biggest film debut ever. **B1**
- ◆ **Math majors and Ph.D.s** are securing million-dollar pay deals from elite trading firms seeking to recruit the best and brightest amid fierce competition from AI companies. **A1**
- ◆ **Major American oil** companies have made little headway in tapping Venezuela's oil fields seven months after the U.S. deposed strongman Nicolás Maduro. **B1**
- ◆ **The first formal** negotiations intended to steer Venezuela toward democracy kicked off without the political opposition's most influential leader. **A7**
- ◆ **OPEC and its allies** pressed ahead with another increase in oil production, aiming to complete the group's return of voluntarily withheld barrels to the market. **B9**
- ◆ **Flight attendants at** WestJet, Canada's second-largest airline, walked off the job after failing to reach an agreement with the carrier, grounding hundreds of flights. **B3**
- ◆ **A group of former** gaming executives are offering the gaming community the chance to power clean-energy projects through a new PlayStation service that costs \$34.99 a year, or \$3.99 a month. **B4**
- ◆ **OpenAI said it has** more than one billion active users and two million businesses using its artificial-intelligence models, an announcement that came after the company said it would cut the price of several models. **B2**

Worldwide

- ◆ **Trump refrained** from a new attack on Iran as mediators made fresh progress on a plan to open the Strait of Hormuz and some Persian Gulf states pressed the president to pursue dialogue with Tehran. **A1**
- ◆ **California's Democratic** Party endorsed the state's proposed billionaire tax in a win for its advocates three months before Californians vote on the measure. **A3**
- ◆ **A divisive Democratic** primary for Senate in Michigan on Tuesday will reveal whether a progressive and socialist groundswell has spread to the U.S. heartland. **A4**
- ◆ **The suspect in a** shooting at an In-N-Out Burger in Twin Falls, Idaho, was a 24-year-old who died from a self-inflicted gunshot wound. **A2**
- ◆ **Wildfires destroyed** hundreds of homes and forced thousands of people to evacuate in eastern Washington state. **A2**
- ◆ **Trump rebuked** Jeanine Pirro, the U.S. attorney for the District of Columbia, after she dropped her effort to prosecute a man for allegedly vandalizing the Reflecting Pool. **A3**
- ◆ **Spain expelled most** of the tens of thousands of migrants who stormed into its enclave of Ceuta in North Africa. **A9**
- ◆ **A dispute involving** domestic-abuse allegations against Ohio Rep. Max Miller was further aired when Sen. Bernie Moreno said his former son-in-law shouldn't continue to serve in Congress. **A4**
- ◆ **At least five** were killed and dozens were missing in a ferry fire in Indonesia. **A9**

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Greece Fights Wildfires as Europe Crisis Spreads



ANADOLU VIA GETTY IMAGES

DIRE BATTLE: Volunteers on Sunday worked to douse a wildfire near Porto Germeno, about 40 miles northwest of Athens. Two Greek firefighting helicopters collided on Sunday while battling a wind-driven fire, killing two crew members. **A9**

Democrats' Biggest Donors Shun Main Party Committee

DNC coffers can't match GOP's haul as backers are giving directly to candidates

George Soros and his son Alex donated more than \$400,000 to the Democratic National Committee during the 2018 midterms. They gave more than \$1 million during the 2022 election cycle, campaign finance records show. This year, they have yet to give the DNC a dollar. The Soroses aren't alone—other high-profile donors have

given little or no money to the Democrats' central committee this year. Reid Hoffman, the co-founder of LinkedIn, wrote steady checks to the DNC for years but during the midterms has yet to give money. In a sign of the party's challenges, a running joke among some donors is that the DNC stands for "Do Not Contribute," said one Democratic strategist who advises major party donors. Months ahead of midterm elections, the Democratic fundraising apparatus has a big donor problem. While many Democratic

By Maggie Severns, Laura J. Nelson and Ken Thomas

elites still feel bullish about taking back the House and are willing to throw big money at their favorite candidates, institutional fatigue—and in some cases, full-on drama—have set in among a number of the party's biggest donors. Like voters, donors say they feel disillusioned with Washington and the party establishment they have long supported. The DNC isn't the only problem spot for Democrats—

other Democratic committees and super PACs lag behind Republicans across the board. It is common for a party that is out of power in Washington to struggle, but Democrats are increasingly concerned it will hurt their chances of winning this fall as Republicans stack up more money in committees and PACs that can organize door-knocking and air TV ads. Some of the problem is the lingering frustration among major donors over how their

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◆ **Michigan primary tests** progressives' clout..... **A4**

Real World Got in Way Of Mogul's Nation Building

By STU WOO AND PATRICIA KOWSMANN

ISKANDAR PUTERI, Malaysia—Tech founder Balaji Srinivasan says he believes the U.S. is descending into anarchy. His solution was to build a new country from scratch. He left Silicon Valley and, as a first step, tried to create a rival tech community in Asia. He set up a campus with co-working spaces, a high-end gym and meals designed by longevity guru Bryan Johnson. He surveyed potential residents on their views on politics and pronatalism, the high-birthrate philosophy Srinivasan promotes. "Bryan Johnson wants to live forever. Sam Altman wants to build a machine of superintelligence. Elon wants to get to Mars," Srinivasan said on a recent podcast. "I just want to start a new country." The setting for this experiment was as surreal as it was grand: a hotel in a \$100 billion, Chinese-built luxury development in Malaysia that became a mostly empty ghost city. Now two years in, his vision—called the Network School—is colliding with the real world. Participants complained about moldy rooms, dead nightlife and not enough women—a downside familiar to Silicon Valley. Then came an even bigger hurdle: the actual country in which they were living. Malaysian authorities launched an investigation into

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Web Slinger's Box Office Pull

Sony Pictures' 'Spider-Man: Brand New Day' opened to an estimated \$927 million in global box-office sales, making it the second-biggest film debut yet, according to the studio. **B1**

Top 10 domestic box office openings of all time

Avengers: Endgame (2019)	\$357 million
Spider-Man: Brand New Day (2026)	355
Spider-Man: No Way Home (2021)	260
Avengers: Infinity War (2018)	258
Star Wars: The Force Awakens (2015)	248
Star Wars: The Last Jedi (2017)	220
Deadpool & Wolverine (2024)	211
Jurassic World (2015)	209
Marvel's The Avengers (2012)	207
Black Panther (2018)	202

Note: Gross revenue for the opening weekend. Spider-Man: Brand New Day is an estimate. Numbers and ranking are not inflation-adjusted. Source: Rentrak

Helicopter Parents Are Co-Piloting Their Adult Children's Careers

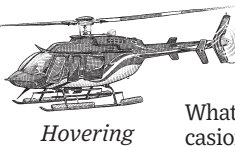
Mom and dad are calling up hiring managers, applying for jobs on kid's behalf

By RAY A. SMITH

Steven Clark had the unpleasant task of firing a 24-year-old—twice. Once was in a brief conversation with the new hire, who had showed up late or not at all four times in his first week at a construction job. Then Clark had to do it all over again, this time with the guy's mother. She called him a few hours later, pleading to give her son another chance. When Clark told her no, things got heated before he ended the call. "I said, 'Look, you know, this is between us and your son. He's the employee,'" says Clark, who

is chief operating officer of a Fairbanks, Alaska-based staffing firm. Gen Zers make up nearly one-fifth of the adult workforce, and bosses and recruiters say it often feels like the nervous parents who hovered over them through childhood and college are right alongside them. What began as the occasional parent ride-along to a job interview coming out of the Covid era is now full-on career "co-piloting," said Jasmine Escalera, head career coach at résumé templates service Zety. More parents are calling up

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Hovering

Trail of Missteps In Guthrie Case

Six months after kidnapping, investigators have made little progress

TUCSON, Ariz.—Savannah Guthrie, the co-host of America's longest-running TV morning show, hoisted her mother onto the national stage

By Valerie Bauerlein, Jared Mitovich and Hannah Critchfield

in November, drawing millions of viewers with a moving video tribute to her family and hometown of Tucson, Ariz. "I grew up there, went to college there, my mom still

lives there," Savannah told her "Today" show audience in the Nov. 5 broadcast. It was the most elaborate of a half-dozen previous episodes that cast a spotlight on her mother, Nancy Guthrie. "Honestly, a part of me has really never left," said Savannah, the family's youngest child.

The video led viewers on an eight-minute tour of Savannah's past. During a stop at the Arizona-Sonora Desert Museum, an owl perched on

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Quant Firms, AI Labs Jockey for Math Stars

By JULIA AMANN

There has never been a better time to be a math nerd. New college graduates and Ph.D.s are now securing million-dollar pay deals from elite trading firms seeking to secure the best and brightest amid fierce competition from artificial-intelligence companies. So-called quant firms, which use sophisticated mathematical models to come up with trades, have for years wooed top young talent with lucrative compensation that big banks struggle to match. Now, the AI boom is pushing those numbers even higher. Just a few years ago, early-career packages pushing seven figures were anomalies, said Matt Stabile, founder of New York-based recruitment firm

Stabile Search. "But a million dollars is something people don't even bat an eye at anymore." "The delineation is pre-OpenAI and post-OpenAI," Stabile added, "that's when you saw competition really take off." The skills required to train large language models have always overlapped with quantitative finance, but the connection has deepened as trading firms have pivoted toward machine learning and AI to power their trades in recent years. Now, AI labs such as OpenAI and Anthropic are vying for the exact same tiny pool of genius math majors and Ph.D.s as Wall Street. The competition poses a challenge for quant firms, which have sought to sweep up

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